



WEEK SEVEN · MODULE TWO

The Interview, Decoded

The confidential note on what is really being asked

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

Almost every question you will be asked at this level is a test of something other than its apparent subject.

This note decodes them. Once you can see the machinery you cannot unsee it, and you will never sit in one of these rooms unprepared again.

Read it, then do the mock interview in Module 3, and read it again afterwards.

CHAPTER I

The questions that are not questions

And what each one is really measuring

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Decode the standard questions.

Answer the question that was actually asked.

What they ask	What they are measuring, and how you fail it
"Tell me about yourself."	Length, and control. They are timing you. Ninety seconds, structured, then stop. The candidate who talks for five minutes has told them exactly what living with her will be like.
"Why did you leave your last role?"	Whether you will criticise. There is no version of the honest, wounded answer that helps you. "The family relocated." "The role changed." "It came to a natural end." Neutral, brief, and then silence, and let them move on.
"What was the hardest thing you dealt with there?"	Two things at once. Whether you have real operational experience, and whether, in telling it, you will disclose something you should not. Give the shape of the problem and the method of the solution, and no identifying detail whatsoever. This is the most dangerous good question in the set.
"Tell me about a mistake you made."	Whether you take responsibility, and whether you can be told things. Give a real one. A small, real, owned mistake, with what you changed afterwards. The candidate who cannot produce a mistake is a candidate who will conceal them.
"How do you handle pressure?"	Nobody wants the answer. They want to see you answer it calmly. The content is irrelevant. The delivery is the entire question.
"What do you know about us?"	Whether you have researched them, and, far more importantly, how much . Knowing their business is diligence. Knowing about their children is a catastrophe, and there is a line, and it is not subtle.
"Where do you see yourself in five years?"	Whether you will leave. Nobody in a private household wants to hire a stepping stone. Ambition is fine. Ambition that visibly points away from their house is not.
"Do you have any questions for us?"	The most revealing question in the interview. Chapter V.

CHAPTER II

How they test your discretion

It will not feel like a test, and that is the design

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the discretion test in the room.

Pass it without appearing to have noticed it.

Somewhere in that interview, you will be invited to be indiscreet. It will be warm. It will feel like rapport. It may come from the principal, from the agency, or from a spouse who is being charming.

And here is the cruel part: **the invitation is often not deliberate**. Sometimes they are genuinely curious. It does not matter at all. The information they take from your answer is identical either way.

The invitation	What it sounds like
The name	"Who were you with before? We probably know them." Said lightly, and quite possibly true.
The story	"Go on, what are they really like?" Warm, laughing, entirely disarming.
The complaint	"That must have been difficult, working for someone like that." An offered sympathy, which is the most effective of all of them, because it is kind.
The peer	A principal names a family, and waits to see whether you will confirm, deny, react, or blink.
The trivial	"Which airline do they use?" Harmless. Entirely harmless. And a test.

THE ANSWER, AND IT IS ALWAYS THE SAME

"I am not able to talk about the families I have worked for. I am sure you would want the same, in time."

Warm. Complete. No apology, no hesitation, no explanation. And then you stop, and you hold their eye, and you do not smile as though you might say more if pressed, because that smile is the failure.

The second half of that sentence, "I am sure you would want the same", is what turns a refusal into a qualification. You have not been difficult. You have shown them, in nine words, exactly what it will be like to be your employer.

And if they push a second time, you repeat it. In the same words, with the same face. A candidate who yields on the second push has told them she yields on the second push.

CHAPTER III

The people who decide

And who are frequently not in the room

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand who is actually consulted.

Behave accordingly, from the gate onwards.

You will believe the decision was made by the person who interviewed you. Very often it was not, or not alone.

Who	What they contribute
The housekeeper who opened the door	Asked, almost always, in a house with long-serving staff. "What did you think of her?" Her answer is not a data point. In many houses it is the decision.
The assistant who booked the meeting	How were you on the telephone. Were you late. Were you demanding about the time. Were you different with her than with them.
The other principal	Frequently not present, frequently the one whose standards govern the house, and frequently the one who says no, quietly, three days later, without a reason being given.
The person they trust who might know you	The back channel from Week 6. Ninety seconds, and it outweighs everything.
The children	Not in any formal sense. And a child who says "I didn't like her" is a fact that no reference can undo.

Which produces one rule, and it is the whole chapter: **the interview began at the gate, and it includes everyone.** The candidate who is warm with the principal and brisk with the housekeeper has already failed, and she will spend a week wondering why she never heard back.

CHAPTER IV

Money

How to talk about it without flinching, and without asking first

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Handle the salary conversation with composure.

Know what your rung actually pays before you enter the room.

4.1 · Who raises it, and when

You do not raise it. Not in a first interview, not with a principal, ever. It goes through the agency or the family office, which is precisely what they are for, and one of the reasons a serious candidate is glad the agency exists.

If they raise it, you answer plainly, immediately, and without apologising. Hesitation here is read as either dishonesty or as not knowing your own worth, and both are expensive.

4.2 · The number

Know it before you walk in. Not a range you hope for: **the actual market band for your rung, in that city.** Week 6 gave you the ladder. If you cannot say your band in one sentence, you are not ready to be asked.

THE FORMULATION

"For a role at this level, in this city, I would expect somewhere between X and Y. But I would rather understand the role properly first, and I am sure we would find the right number."

Direct, unembarrassed, and it hands the conversation back without conceding anything. Then stop talking. The next person to speak has conceded, and it will not be you.

4.3 · What you never do

- **Never apologise for a number.** "I know it is a lot, but..." You have just negotiated against yourself, and they heard it.
- **Never inflate your current salary.** It is checkable, it is often checked, and being caught on this single point ends a candidacy instantly, in a market where you have one asset.

- **Never accept on the spot out of gratitude.** "Thank you, may I confirm tomorrow morning" is a complete, professional, and entirely normal sentence, and it is also a small demonstration of exactly the composure they are buying.

CHAPTER V

The questions you ask

The most revealing four minutes of the interview

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Ask questions that demonstrate the work rather than the wanting.

"Do you have any questions for us?" is not a courtesy. It is the last test, and it is the one that most often changes an interviewer's mind, in both directions.

Because your questions reveal, with total accuracy, what you are actually interested in.

The question you ask	What it tells them
"How is the staff structured, and who would I coordinate with?"	You are thinking about the work, and about other people, and you understand that you will have responsibility without authority.
"What does this role find most difficult?"	You are serious, you are not naive, and you have asked the one question that will get you an honest and useful answer.
"What would a good first ninety days look like to you?"	You are already inside the role. This question, in my experience, is the one that most often ends the interview well.
"How do you prefer to be communicated with, and how often?"	You understand that their attention is the product. Nobody asks this. It lands every time.
"What happened to the person who was here before?"	Bold, and entirely legitimate, and asked calmly it is a mark of seriousness. The answer will tell you more about the house than anything else in the interview.

And the questions that end you, quietly, in the last four minutes:

- **Anything about their private life, their business, or their children**, however innocently framed. You have just demonstrated the exact appetite that this profession cannot accommodate.
- **Anything about the travel in an excited way.** "Would I go with them to the chalet?" You have told them you want the life, not the job.
- **Anything about time off, first.** Legitimate, necessary, and it belongs to the family office and to the offer stage, and not to the first four minutes you have alone with a principal.
- **Nothing at all.** "No, I think you have covered everything." You have just told them that you are not thinking. Never arrive without three questions written in the notebook you brought.

CHAPTER VI

Case law

*Six interviews***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Recognise these before you are in one.

The name

A final interview, in a house in London. Everything had gone well for fifty minutes. And then the principal, pleasantly, in the manner of a man making conversation at the end of a good meeting, said: "So who were you with before? We probably know them."

She said the name. It was a small thing. She had left on good terms, she was proud of the role, and he had asked so warmly.

She was not offered the position. Nothing was said. **He had learned, in one sentence,** exactly what would be said about him in the next interview she ever attended.

The one who repeated herself

The same question, in a different house, to a different candidate. "Who were you with before?"

"I am not able to talk about the families I have worked for. I am sure you would want the same, in time."

He pressed once, lightly, still smiling. She said it again. Exactly the same words. Same expression, no apology, and she did not look away.

She was offered the role that week. He told the agency afterwards that it was the only moment in the interview that had told him anything at all. **He had not been curious. He had been recruiting.**

The housekeeper

A candidate arrived, was let in by the housekeeper, and was charming for fifty minutes with the principal, and it went, by every visible measure, extremely well.

On the way out she handed the housekeeper her coat without looking at her.

That evening the principal asked, as he always did, what she had thought. **The housekeeper had been in that house for nineteen years, and she said one sentence, and it ended the candidacy.** The candidate never learned that the interview had not ended when she left the drawing room.

The five minutes

"Tell me about yourself."

He spoke for six and a half minutes. Everything he said was true, relevant, and impressive.

The interviewer, who had been listening for ninety seconds and then timing him, wrote one word in the margin, and the word was "tiring". **A household is a small space, over many years, and a person who cannot stop is a person you cannot live with, however good she is.**

The question about the chalet

She was excellent. Genuinely, technically excellent, and everyone in the room knew it.

At the end: "Do you have any questions?" And she said, with real warmth and a bright smile: "Would I get to travel with the family to Courchevel?"

She did not get the role, and she would have been the best candidate they saw. **In one sentence she had told them that she wanted the life rather than the work,** and that is the one appetite a household cannot have inside it.

The ninety days

A candidate with less experience than two others on the list, and a rung below where the family had been looking.

At the end, she asked one question: "What would a good first ninety days look like to you?"

The principal talked for eleven minutes. He had never been asked it. He said afterwards that it was the moment he decided, and that he could not entirely explain why. **She had stopped being a candidate and started being the person in the role, and she did it in a single sentence, and she did it by asking about them and not about herself.**

Glossary

The invitation · The warm, disarming, frequently unintentional prompt to be indiscreet. It will happen in every interview you ever attend.

The second push · When they ask again. Yielding here tells them you yield. Repeat the same words, with the same face.

The back channel · The person they trust who might know you. Ninety seconds, and it outweighs your entire dossier.

The ninety-second rule · The correct length of "tell me about yourself". They are timing you, and they will not say so.

The wanting · The visible appetite for the life rather than the work. It is felt across a room, and it is fatal.

The last four minutes · Your questions. The most revealing part of the interview, and the part nobody prepares.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing, out loud, and then again in front of a camera.

1. "Tell me about yourself." Write it. Ninety seconds. Time it. Then cut it by a quarter.
2. "Why did you leave your last role?" Write the neutral version. Then write the wounded version, and read them both aloud, and notice which one you would hire.
3. "What was the hardest thing you handled there?" Give the shape and the method, with no identifying detail at all. Then reread it and remove the two details you did not notice you left in.
4. The principal names a family and waits. Write exactly what you say, and describe your face.
5. He pushes a second time, warmly. What do you do?
6. Explain why "I am sure you would want the same, in time" turns a refusal into a qualification.
7. Who, other than your interviewer, will be consulted about you? Name five, and say what each one saw.
8. What is the market band for your rung, in your city? One sentence. If you cannot, you are not ready to be asked.
9. Write your three questions for the end of the interview. Then check each one: is it about the work, or about the life?
10. Of the six cases, which one is you? Do not choose the flattering answer.

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